

PROSOLAR MECHANICS - OPERATIONS MANUAL



THE NEW SCIENCE OF SOUND

Series 6498A: Colleges don't offer Prosolar Mechanics

Title 1: Maybe you're not good enough, after all. Before it gets any worse, catch yourself. Stop your degrading and self-obsessed whining about how you've always been rejected by

your parents, your teachers, your peers, your coworkers and whoever else is left in mainstream society. Realize that you are just like them, and the more time you sit home watching cable, playing video games and surfing the internet, the more forgettable you are becoming. This is happening by the minute. There is no piercing, tattooing, or hairstyle to cop, there is no gadget, automobile or computer that you can buy, there are no horror movies to withstand and there are no bands you can follow that will save you any more. Convince yourself to do better. Find a way.

i wonder if this message is ever going to reach the others - the first ones. this isolation is giving me grave doubts. i have been under for so long i am even beginning to doubt my own moment of clarity.

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Title 2-1: Only a slight relevance to a real life.

Somewhere, there is a universe where actors, athletes and rock stars are known for the greedy, slack and self-important lowlifes that they truly are. In this other world, scientists, mechanics, daycare workers, firefighters, teachers and EMTs live the high life. Their every word is hyped and their every action is noted and idealized by the adoring public. Young people aspire to be more like them and dream of being discovered by academy recruiters one day so they may join the ranks of this public-serving elite.

Title 2-2. We are all the enemy.

In every story heroes exist in order to keep some compromising force at bay. In this case that element is an amorphous, life-sucking parasite that seeks to sedate the masses through the creation of an intricate web of unreality. False stories are spread through various media that perpetuate lies about what is and what is not possible for an individual to achieve in a lifetime. This complicated system cannot be viewed from above nor from without and yet all beings are inextricably linked to it.

Title 2-3. There is no known cure.

You cannot fight the system. Repeat. You cannot fight the system.

what internal smiles as the lines play like sound in my head, what a
setup, what a coup!

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Title 2-3. There is no known cure.

The only known weapon against complete absorption of creative culture into the systemic consumptive void is regular complex stimulation of the prefrontal cortex. Stimulation en masse isn't so easy to achieve. Best case scenario: a continuous onslaught of sound, pictures and words that are so true, so provocative and so accepting that one engages fully. Now the heroes are any and all individuals who work to generate new frequencies of creation across disciplines, disseminating their output to every individual they can reach.

Title 2-4. New professionals for age old problems.

Prosolar Mechanics are supposedly the professionals in this new science of sound, experimenting with different combinations of pitches, frequencies and wave patterns in an attempt to strengthen the autonomy of all individuals coming into contact. They claim to have been chartered by the Real Prosolar Mechanics, a group of characters that never actually existed outside of a graphic novel, didn't exist for long and were little known outside of obscure comic collectors, and yet they are the only known entity with any authority over them.

the question was raised repeatedly over the years by those closest to me, have you taken the metaphor too far? this wasn't our idea and we're not even sure we like it. (i really tried to explain it better. this story made so much more sense to me in light of what we were doing. how did they not see it?) we're not trying to be like the comic book, they said. why are you doing this? we don't understand. what does this have to do with the music? one said, i just see this as a

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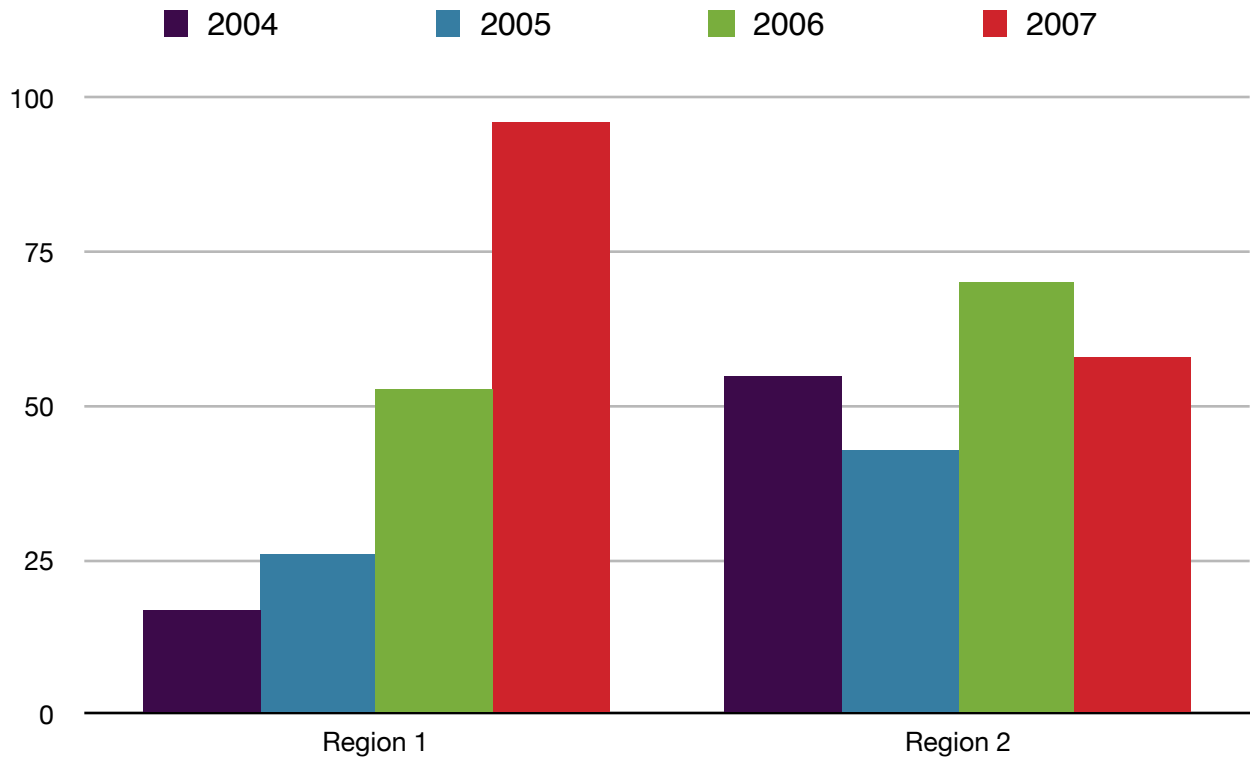
nice side outlet for you. but i don't think you should take it any further. it doesn't have anything to do with the rest of us. so enjoy yourself but try not to get too carried away with it. i tried to listen. for years i listened and for years i restrained the impulse to lose myself in the metaphor. but the metaphor started making more sense than the premise. then the premise was gone and the metaphor was all that was left.

Title 3. You're buying.

Here at Prosolar Labs, we aim to provide the modern science consumer with the latest in high-quality life enhancement systems. Prosolar Mechanics work around the clock to ensure you that the most up-to-date and reliable resources are harvested and re-generated in order to sustain and expand your capacity for consuming the best in today's sound. Guaranteed or your money back! (In some states certain restrictions may apply. Please refer to your locality's zoning ordinances.)

Title 4. 100 degrees and rising.

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Most likely, it will hit 100 degrees Fahrenheit in the remote command post today but the work continues. Climate control is no option at this station due to the unique and fragile structure of the holding tank. Mechanics work in tank tops and cut-offs while fur-covered aliens lie motionless in places low to the ground. Heat rises.

Title 5. Prosolar Mechanics harvest the bullet tree.

New Brunswick, NJ. Few realize how desperate we are to find a way off of this planet. We can't figure out how we are going to survive while we search for a fuel source for the ship. The so-called vegetation we have found seems to be only more ammunition and it is hazardous for mechanics to eat bullets. Stories about people acting like heroes, exploring space and chasing aliens are all the rage at overpriced theaters in strip-malls everywhere, but Prosolar Mechanics know a wholly different kind of rage. There is a map embedded deep in your subcon-

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scious that will lead you to us, stranded beneath the bullet tree. We are hungry so please bring burritos.

Title 6. Not all of us are going to reach old age.

Sometimes I get the feeling like something or someone is out to get us. We are being tested and we no longer know whom to trust.

a question was raised repeatedly over the years by those closest to me, have you taken the metaphor too far? too far? it hurts to laugh at them now, knowing i hadn't taken it nearly far enough.

SERIES 101798A: Communication with the Living, Part 2.

Title 1. Internet killed the cable star.

We wonder how many of you have found a way into the compound. This fall feels nothing like the summer and we are strapped for provisions for the coming season. Mechanics harvest the last of the grenades from the banks of oil-drenched rivers and take cover in alien dens. These hosts do not like our recipes for merriment and we might be out-staying our welcome in this place. If you are receiving this, please send a transmission to our board of directors.

the question was raised repeatedly over the years by those closest to me, have you taken the metaphor too far?

Title 2-1. There is no time like the present.

ENTRY#: 0914199812:12p

MECHANIC ID#: 03141969

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DESTINATION: The Budapest, New Brunswick NJ

REPORT:

This place seems on the edge of eruption or complete annihilation, and of the two I can't tell which is the more likely outcome.

Sometimes when Prosolar Mechanics set out to break open the local landscape, I imagine we are landing in a home port after a long and tiring mission. I try to imagine a homecoming of sorts. The faces will be familiar and appreciative. The mission is a celebration, and our job is to do what we can to ensure the crowd participates to their fullest. Drinking, dancing, swaying back and forth and inciting as much mayhem as possible. Loud and yet barely audible conversations about the state of indie music and the scene.

What will happen if in ten years we look back on ourselves and see that in 1998, while we were pining away for past and more exciting times (the 70's? Are you kidding? Even the 80's are a decade away now...), we somehow missed the good time we were having right now?

So I was having a good time. I was drinking and dancing all night. I would flit about the club, sharing winks, nods, hugs and kisses with my coconspirators and potential audience all night.

And the attention was on us as we struggled to make our exorbitant amount of technology work. Just work. That's all we asked. I was drunk and harassing my bandmates on stage before we even played a single note.

The set kicked up and all was well, despite my lax demeanor accompanying a couple shots of vodka. You know, I rarely mix alcohol with performing live because I am just too nervous that I will fuck up the music. But tonight it only made a difference in the fact that I was

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goading Mike and Alex before the set. My voice was nervous and I could feel it quivering over the PA during the first couple of tunes. I sang louder and thought, "Oh shit-I don't want to do that overly-aggressive because I can't hold a pitch style vocal..." Such an obvious cover-up for nervous vocal chords. I sang through it though. I think it got better as we went along. Who knows? You can't actually hear much from stage. I could hear enough to be nervous though. Alex's whammy pedal took a nose dive during its most important moment--Heaven Grand. We deal with these minor catastrophes as they arise. Then at the end of the set, during our newest song, somehow my guitar chord got pulled from my tuner, and Dave had to just keep playing while Mike, Alex and I struggled to find out why I had no sound. I adore those moments on stage. They are the moments I keep.

It was over. We said our farewells to the hub city locals and packed the ship for our return to the lab. Roadkill littered the route back, and the mechanics were beat from the long night.

These nights I record because as I stated just above, what if? The simple and perhaps sometimes sad truth is, these are the good times. They are the only times. Lately I have caught myself in a worrisome trap of mourning times recently past. I miss the heyday of Joy Division and even a few years ago in our local scene. I have been caught reminiscing about things that are at this point long gone from the moment. Yet, this right now is my youth, my life. While below the surface I often scramble to distinguish that which is meaningful to me and perhaps meaningful on some deeper level, at face value I think what I really need is to be enjoying my life and the work I devote myself to.

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I have said and will again say this pursuit of sound is not really about fun. And I still mean that. I don't do it to have fun. I do it because I have something I want you to hear, something I hear deep in the most remote part of my brain and my life. I have a lot to say to you, to anyone who is willing to hear it, do something with it, and then in return give me a piece of themselves. Or just give a piece of themselves to anyone else. It's about that for me. And it is fun.

Sometimes it is painful and sometimes it is dull, but it is my life and I think I may be enjoying it afterall.

I believe that sound is one of the ways you experience life. It has become central to my own, and my life is about exploration. These days I am obsessed with exploration of all kinds of connections and time travel. What can I say about all of this? I just don't want to look back someday and realize that all I did in my 20's was worry and feel unfulfilled.

So this record that you may be reading is about Prosolar Mechanics. Please realize that Prosolar Mechanics means something quite specific to me, and it might mean something entirely different to the other mechanics. But we are all saying similar things. To me the Prosolar Mechanic is the technician that seeks to keep the underground viable in the 21st century. A person who tries to create something for the sake of creation, and for no other reason. We watch what it does once it takes a life of its own. There is a difference between a song that you play and a song that plays itself through you. I want to be that conduit for some other life. That's how important the whole damned thing is to me. The common ground is where we all gather together and do something--anything that signifies that we were once alive and felt

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something about that. Being drunk in a bar with friends and pouring your heart out has its significance. So you can join us too. Maybe you already have.

the question was raised repeatedly over the years by those closest to me, have you taken the metaphor too far? so i decided, yes, i've probably taken it too far. but that's only because i'd much rather be there than here. and i do believe that if i simply think differently, i will be there, and not here, in this world that has been created and defined by everyone except me. i won't have it any longer.

Title 2-2. There is no time like the present.

Title 2-3. There is no time like the present.

Recruiting agents scour the known universe in search of order. There are those of us who wonder whether armageddon is close at hand but certain mechanics don't pay any attention. Some of us have to stay detached enough to pilot the rig into port.

Title 3. You might not be good enough, but you are the only one left. There aren't any more leaders except you, and you had better stop waiting for your life to be on the line. By then it will already be too late. Stop banging your head on the academy gates and stop daring everyone else to do a better job. It doesn't matter how badly you've been treated. There is no excuse left and not one that matters when your future is being determined by some collective fear. You will fail; just accept it. And do it anyway.

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Title 3-1. Mechanics come in more than one.

ENTRY#: 1023199811:51p

MECHANIC ID#: 04251964

DESTINATION: 1992

REPORT:

We were on what seemed at first to be a simple recon job, plus a little salvage, of an abandoned personnel carrier outside Prowler IV. But strange things started happening when we ran a regen of the ship's logs before doing a memory dump. We came up with THIS. After that all hell broke loose. I seem to be having difficulty with my temporal framework. The Doc doesn't know what to do either. Suggested I see a psychobiologist when we get back on the surface, or at least somewhere halfway civilized.

Title 4. It's getting away.

There was a point at which prosolar mechanics could have offered some protection from another night of dreading the next morning at work. But they weren't convinced. (Endorsements are slow to follow mechanics who show little interest in the asian economy.) There is nothing left to entice them with except the product that is slow to reach the bread bins. There's no need to stand in line any longer if you have a modem and an evening free from anticipated phone calls.

Title 4-1.

ENTRY#: 1123199811:32a

MECHANIC ID#: 03141969

DESTINATION: Somewhere halfway civilized

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REPORT

For at least ten days I had had an unrelenting headache. During the week I'd been popping Zantac (not to be confused with XANAX) regularly as every meal caused such intense abdominal pain that the mere sight of food, any food, began to inspire serious pangs of fear. The week passed with only one clinically significant panic attack, experienced in the car, on my way to my daily routine. So while I felt concerned that perhaps I was headed back down into some personal pit of malaise-induced hell, I could at least see that I wasn't totally sunk yet.

I'm still not exactly sure what to make of it all, but I feel stronger now and ready to take myself apart again.

I was talking about our week, trying to explain that we had been working very, very hard to put our set back in order after many, many weeks of trying to finish recording and generate new material. It was a much rougher task than we had expected, especially given that I was a literal wreck the entire time. Up until the moment we took the stage I wasn't convinced I'd make it at all.

You see, sometimes when I am trapped between the necessity of earning money and the necessity of pursuing this business of space exploration, it's all I can do just to look down and gaze at my feet. If I were to look up, I think I'd feel as though I couldn't take the speed of life. I feel constantly stuck in some sort of slow motion or time warp, and as though I will arrive at my 100th year on earth feeling as though I still hadn't gotten all the work done. There is too much, and not enough time. There's not enough time to live, it seems.

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I sent out a plea, a warning perhaps, to the subscribers of the promechx mailer, that I was letting go. I was planning a complete dissolution of the self, in the hopes of draining my thirst and my anger and reaching some state of consciousness where I could know that my constant motion in the day to day living had a point of rest. That I could just let myself be. And this is why I remain a Prosolar Mechanic today, despite all the other pressures and pursuits I've undertaken as of late. Because it's through this listening and this production of sound that personally, I can't help but dissolve totally and let my ego--my consciousness--take a well deserved break. In the break you can really experience the moment.

The truth is, sometimes I can see just how ridiculous all of this seems. It feels so complicated, but like good sex, you just have to forget about the constructed realities you've spent your entire conscious life building up in order to keep the chaos of existence at bay. Sometimes, you need to lose it in the chaos in order to keep yourself honest.

The show was good, by the way. Plenty of faces, and many of them new to us. It was definitely not our top performance, given my health and of course, those technical problems that tend to plague us every time we try bringing the sound home. But it was happening--that dissolution crap I was talking about above, and it was happening all around me. In my best hopes, that dissolving doesn't begin and end with me or the mechanics. It spreads like sleep through the hypnotic body, and it takes those within reach to their various points of rest. But it isn't restful. It's just the point of embarkment.

Title 7. Enough is enough.

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As I gaze upon another industrial sunset, across the street a 5 year old boy whacks the dead branch of a small tree with a plastic wrench. I ask, "What are you doing?" "Fixing it," he pronounces. "What's wrong with it?" "It's broke," he explains. "Are you some kind of tree mechanic?" "Yes." Whack, whack.

Title 8. Communication with the living.

Training in transuniversal communications allows the individual access to any point in time through a readjustment of the temporal perception lens. More tests are being conducted in order to ensure the procedure's safety before the FDA will allow it on the market.

Title 9. We hear better in the dark.

The mechanics are currently testing the relationship between light and sound. This procedure requires maximum security restrictions for the labs because intruders are just as difficult to detect when one's eyes are closed. There was a point to determine somewhere along the way but in the daily living it became obscured by this notion of getting by. (Sometimes, light is just another excuse for leaving one's bed.) There is a specific formula one can follow in order to measure the degree of disorientation associated with sound in the dark.

Step 1: Turn the stereo up.

Step 2: Turn the lights off.

This experiment can be tried at home with proper precautions provided for (see note 101898-T9a).

Title 10. Mechanics come in more than one.

ENTRY#: 1223199810:10p

MECHANIC ID#: 04251964

DESTINATION: Melodian (with an angry mob of misfit superstars)

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REPORT

We've nearly finished overhauling the ship, but it's gonna take a while before we've got all the bugs figured out if last Friday is any indicator.

Mike was having a major problem with the thrust balancers right before blast off. I thought he was going to shit when we tried to take off before he figured out that it was just a problem with a limiter switch. Actually, he didn't guess it was the limiter on the red unit until we hit "The Body Spills" outside E's gravitational range, just before the LaGrange point in the manifold. Of course, as soon as he hit the switch, he had to recalibrate the balance under the gun. We could have been torn apart if the acceleration had hit us before he'd finished. Even before that, Amy had a major reverb malfunction, spraying feedback all over the second section of Cosmopolitan. Accidents like that are what took out the Challenger.

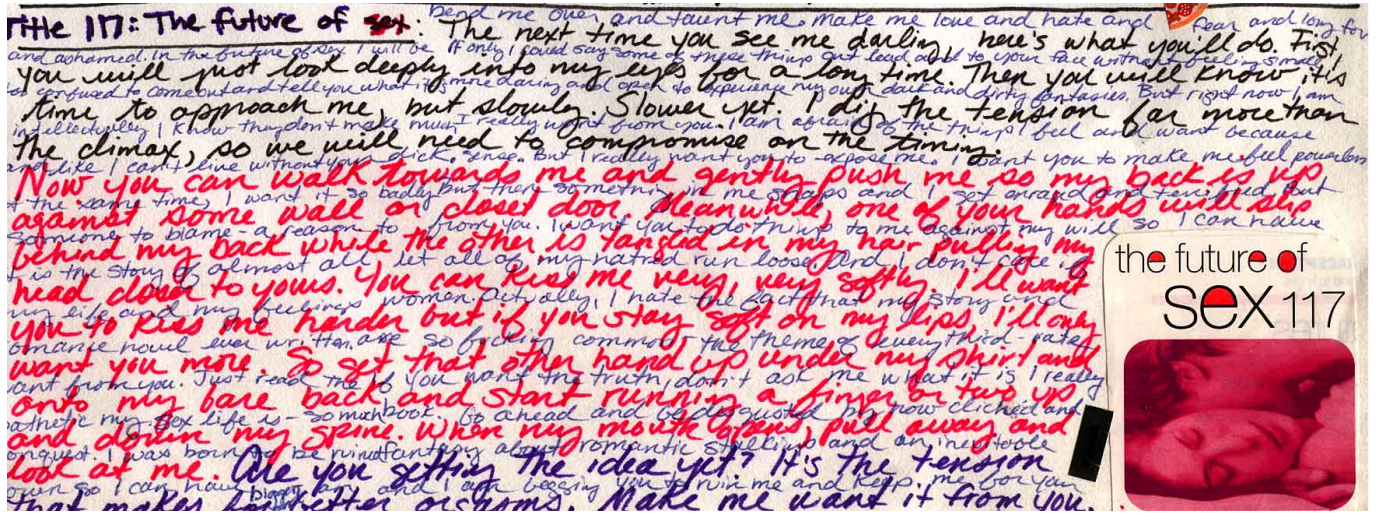
To top it off I had borrowed a quad12 for the gig, which I thought would have worked about the same as mine (both made by Mars Hall) but the Mesa/Ground Control combination didn't interface with it in the same way. I couldn't hear shit, though I was louder than bombs. Suffice it to say, I was way out of tune in "The Body Spills." That song nearly killed us.

Dave didn't seem to have any problems, lucky for us. Lose the power plant and it's all over – nobody can hear you scream.

But after that, we hit the LaGrange point and gravity took over, taking us and about 20 innocent but willing bystanders to the outer reaches of the solar system. It wasn't our best mission, but we did complete it. First in, last out.

You were here.

Series I don't remember



Title 114. I am the complex.

I have now spent over 15 months underground, in the mines, pretending I was one of them and looking for any and all opportunities for espionage. I thought I would go unnoticed. Monsters harvest broken hearts for fuel, feeding the fat while sleeping youth lay dreaming in their laps. I enlisted as an undercover mechanic. My purpose was to secretly distribute the new science to the sleeping. But as I poke around the sub-territories I realize that I am not actually awake after all, and in fact I am not sure where I am. I may have crossed the line between soldier and captive but there are no guards here to ask. I search my memories for a map to consciousness and the code to open my eyes. I sense the others are nearby but as the artificial lights begin to glow I cannot hear them. We hear better in the dark.

Title 115. I am looking for a new home for Prosolar Mechanics.

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This place is damp and the bullet tree sags from the weight such moisture. I want to approach the lake so I can swim and wash your hateful thoughts from my skin, but the mud lining these banks is too deep. I am afraid of sticking to the ground and needing your strength to pull me free.

Title 116. Trust no one.

Morning report indicated that footsteps were heard on the upper balcony at apx. 2:17 this morning. Guards have been sent to patrol the perimeter of the station, but no intruders have been found. Down below the masses might be praying for light to penetrate cracks in their cells in order to stimulate the primary generation of names. But in the present those lives remain nameless. The prison stays invisible and slowly the urge turns to a light itch. Then nothing. The so-called leaders bring coffee and the morning paper to those starving for bread, but they read and take in the new nutrients; style and caffeine. Somewhere beyond here the real Prosolar Mechanics fear for our survival and do nothing. My frustration turns to yen and I am asleep again.

Title 118. Put free time to good use.

You live in a world where you have precious few choices and and little time to make them, and you know that. You say prayers in your sleep that you cannot remember upon waking. You do not believe in God, but you don't disbelieve either. Things were once easier for you, but now that you've given up on the notion of having any real identity for

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yourself you can't seem to understand why you bother to wake up at all, and each day. Bother. Figure out why.

Title 119. The mechanics are desperate like me.

Unrehearsed even though thousands of hours in places like these adults are desperate and mean overdressed even though thousands of dollars and magazines tripping wires long ago dead so speech flows and reaches sorrows adults are desperate like mechanics marooned for life on distant planets babies born of time and panic what i would do if i'd remember to humans are born and then they're gone infinite worlds maintained in one we contact none adults are stranded left on planets marooned for life by mathematics equations solve time with panic what i would do if i'd remember to.

Title 120.

We have been conducting more tests over in the lab because the complex seems to have mutated again. It used to seem as though the lethargy seeped in through orifices. Now we suspect it spontaneously erupts from within. No one is safe and we need all the recruits we can muster to keep fighting before we've all rolled over for the last few minutes before the alarm goes off. By then it might be too late. I've opened my eyes for the fourth time this morning without ever closing them in between and the landscapes become more bizarre with each awakening. Where the hell are the others with the ship? If you see them, please let them know I need a hand correcting the spelling on my application to the Academy.

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Part Four

title 2003.

things are happening now. i don't feel the way i once did about this place and i've finally decided to get going. much of my time here has been spent trying to reach understanding, trying to create understanding out of circumstances. i am not sure after all if the circumstances are not better left meaningless. it doesn't matter anymore, because i'm leaving it all behind. i am off today, and i do not plan to return.

if you've never read this series before and you don't understand what you are reading i will try to explain.

in the beginning i thought there were two types of space travel - the space outside of your body and the space inside of your head. i finally realized this week that i'd had it kind of wrong.

i think the space is all there is. your body is just biology that puts a boundary around some of it. we become so attached to that space taken by our bodies and our things. we never want to leave it and we do what we can to deny or put off thinking about that day, that split second we will vacate for good and become one again with all the rest that is.

i think we miss out. we are driven to avoidance, denial by our fears of disappearing. we are afraid to be human and perishable.

this month someone who was once very close to me died without warning or meaning or any reason that any human can know. and i became sickened, saddened and fearful. because i understood innately that i can die like that too, and so can you, and so can alex and mike and any

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number of people i love. and there doesn't have to be any meaning in it. it's just the nature of humanity - we all die.

and nobody, nobody knows what happens next. i don't care what anyone says. nobody knows. yet the absence of some concrete knowledge about what happens after death is so terrifying we tell ourselves anything and we believe it because we couldn't otherwise bear the loss and the grief and the fear of just being gone. we can't live with the questions. we create answers and meanings for events. i am so afraid we do that and then we can't see what simply is.

we need to find a way to help each other. to really help each other. not to tell each other what to think, or to pretend to have answers, or to even distract us from being afraid. we need to help each other just be afraid when life is scary and not cheat ourselves from experience or the insight it can bring.

and sometimes we do help each other, in ways we don't intend or at times we didn't think of. i was helped through this specific event by unlikely people in strange places. i was allowed to just be afraid and in agony and sad and all those things we normally try to skip over in life. and it wasn't pleasant but now i can sleep at night and focus on where i've got to go next in life.

and although i haven't picked the specific destination, i know i won't stay here. there's too much out there i've got to go and check out while i'm on this planet.

PART V

Title 060202 Daylight.

I am giving my vocabulary back to the Institution. I won't need it where I'm headed now. I've been underground for so long that I be-

lieved words were all that I had to keep me level, but now again, everything has changed. Fast as I can dig tunnels are caving in closing options for me and the other survivors. Words fail. Before today I hadn't the heart to say it aloud but I no longer believe the mechanics are coming. I've been waiting but I'm pretty certain I've had it wrong for most of the whole time. It has been an endless night. I once liked that. Felt like home. Me and the space. The space underground. Confining, free from motion. Nothing to do but dig. I thought they would come but they haven't. I wonder if they're trapped somewhere. I wonder what's happened to the ship. I wonder what happened to our arsenal and if the board is disappointed with our performance. I half expect to be disbarred by now. That is, if there's any authority left to strip me of my credentials. With the absolute lack of transmission down here it's nearly impossible to tell, but I just don't feel the force of the mission as I once did. It's a feeling of sickness. A deep depression. I don't know if I'm going to escape. And now I'm not sure if it matters.